

problem.

I was in charge of the product development team, small though it was in those days, and shared with my cofounders the sense that the problem had to be with my team's efforts. I worked harder, tried to focus on higher- and higher-quality features, and lost a lot of sleep. Our frustration grew. When I could think of nothing else to do, I was finally ready to turn to the last resort: talking to customers. Armed with our failure to make progress tuning our engine of growth, I was ready to ask the right questions.

Before this failure, in the company's earliest days, it was easy to talk to potential customers and come away convinced we were on the right track. In fact, when we would invite customers into the office for in-person interviews and usability tests, it was easy to dismiss negative feedback. If they didn't want to use the product, I assumed they were not in our target market. "Fire that customer," I'd say to the person responsible for recruiting for our tests. "Find me someone in our target demographic." If the next customer was more positive, I would take it as confirmation that I was right in my targeting. If not, I'd fire another customer and try again.

By contrast, once I had data in hand, my interactions with customers changed. Suddenly I had urgent questions that needed answering: Why aren't customers responding to our product "improvements"? Why isn't our hard work paying off? For example, we kept making it easier and easier for customers to use IMVU with their existing friends. Unfortunately, customers didn't want to engage in that behavior. Making it easier to use was totally beside the point. Once we knew what to look for, genuine understanding came much faster. As was described in [Chapter 3](#), this eventually led to a critically important pivot: away from an IM add-on used with existing friends and toward a stand-alone network one can use to make new friends. Suddenly, our worries about productivity vanished. Once our efforts were aligned with what customers really wanted, our experiments were much more likely to change their behavior for the better.

This pattern would repeat time and again, from the days when we were making less than a thousand dollars in revenue per month